

County Administration Workshop: September 1, 2026

1:30 p.m. - Board of Commissioners Conference Room

Attending: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman,
Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:30 p.m.

1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest

The Board declared there were no potential conflicts of interest.

2. Department Business

a. Legal

1. Special Service District for DA-Juvenile Justice-Jail

Tabled because Legal Counsel was not present.

2. Agenda Modifications

Tabled because Legal Counsel was not present.

b. Information Technology

1. Strategic Communication Planning

Thomas Gray, Public Information Officer, provided an update on the County strategic communications work. He reported that communications materials for the Firewise defensible-space project were completed and promotional scheduling had begun. The leadership feedback period for the Strategic Communications Plan was complete, with comments received from more than half of County leadership; a revised draft would be circulated the following week, with a near-final version anticipated by September 15. Gray also reported that updates to the social media and public records policies were nearly complete and would be returned to Legal Counsel for review. At Gray's request, the Board agreed to extend the AI pilot-project wrap-up by one week, from September 11 to September 18, due to staff vacations that delayed implementation work.

2. Packet Posting for the Public

Commissioner Richardson proposed resuming the practice of posting the Board's meeting packet with the public agenda on the County website, except for materials properly identified as confidential. The Board discussed transparency, public-records requests, media access, website placement, and the need for an internal review process to ensure sensitive or confidential material is not inadvertently posted. Gray advised that posting agenda packets is a common local-government transparency practice and could be accomplished without significant website changes. The Board agreed that Legal Counsel and departments should continue identifying confidential materials before submission. Without objection, the Board authorized the Board Secretary to begin posting public agenda packets with meeting agendas, using a careful rollout and appropriate review for confidential material.

c. Community Corrections

1. Agreement to Rent Real Property at 1112 NE D Street and Application for Real Property Tax Exemption

Scott Hyde, Community Justice Director, presented renewal of the County's lease at 1112 NE D Street and the related application for real property tax exemption. The County has leased the residence since 2017 for its transitional housing program. The renewed term would run from October 2026 through September 2027 at \$1,500 per month, approximately a seven-percent increase from the prior year but still below the estimated market rent of approximately \$1,995 per month. Hyde explained that the residence generally houses four to six individuals on parole or probation and is monitored through Welcome Home Oregon. The program provides a

stable, clean-and-sober reentry environment while participants obtain employment, save money, and transition to independent housing. Community Justice currently has approximately 30 transitional-housing beds for men and women, with much of the program supported by grant and Justice Reinvestment funding. The property-tax exemption has been part of the lease arrangement since the program began and is reflected in the below-market rent.

Commissioner Richardson moved to approve the Agreement to Rent Real Property at 1112 NE D Street and the Application for Real Property Tax Exemption, and authorize Director Hyde to sign. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes; Commissioner Martin – Yes; Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

2. In-State Travel Authorization

Scott Hyde, Community Justice Director, requested blanket authorization for recurring in-state overnight travel to Oregon Association of Community Corrections Directors meetings. Hyde serves both with the full association and its executive team; the meetings alternate by month and generally require one overnight stay, occasionally two depending on location. He advised that the authorization would cover approximately 95 percent of his anticipated travel requests.

Commissioner Martin moved to approve the in-state travel authorization as presented. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes; Commissioner Martin – Yes; Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

d. Finance

1. Board Order 2026-044 – Josephine County Economic Development Grant Advisory Committee

Matt Eide, Finance Director, presented Board Order No. 2026-044, carrying forward the Board's prior direction to reduce the Josephine County Economic Development Grant Advisory Committee from seven members to five. The revised membership consists of two business-owner positions and three members at large, with the prior small-business employee-count restriction removed. The Board had no additional questions regarding the revised membership structure.

Commissioner Martin moved to approve Board Order No. 2026-044 as presented. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes; Commissioner Martin – Yes; Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

2. Board Order 2026-045 - Accepting By-Laws

Matt Eide, Finance Director, presented the revised proposed By-Laws for the Josephine County Economic Development Grant Advisory Committee. The Board discussed strengthening conflict-of-interest provisions, including requiring members to disclose conflicts and, if a conflict arises involving an applicant for grant funds, to resign from the committee rather than participate in decisions affecting competing applications. The Board also reviewed quorum and tie-vote provisions; a majority of filled positions constitutes a quorum, and any tie recommendation would be referred to the Board of Commissioners. The Board requested revised conflict-of-interest language and tabled Board Order No. 2026-045 until the next County Administration Workshop. Eide advised that the process of interviewing applicants for the five committee positions could proceed while the By-Laws were being finalized.

3. New Economic Development Grant Application

Matt Eide, Finance Director, presented the updated Economic Development Grant application previously circulated to the Board. The revised application included additional qualifying questions and was intended to provide a clearer and more consistent annual grant-review process. The Board expressed support for the revised application.

The Board approved the new Economic Development Grant application without objection.

e. Human Resources

1. Personnel Actions

Natalie Eckhardt-Doupe, Interim Human Resources Director, presented personnel reclassification actions resulting from the County's recent compensation survey: Sheriff's Department Lead Dispatcher - Reclass Up; Animal Control Supervisor - Reclass Up; two Lieutenant positions - Reclass Up; and Undersheriff - Reclass Up. Eckhardt-Doupe explained that the actions implement the updated placement on the pay scale following the classification review, the first broad review of this type in approximately six years. The Board approved the personnel actions without objection.

3. Board Business

a. Recommendation of Re-Appointments to the Josephine County Mining Advisory Committee - Don Bellville - At Large and Joel Perkins - At Large

The Board discussed Resolution No. 2026-033, which would reappoint Don Bellville and Joel Perkins as At-Large members of the Josephine County Mining Advisory Committee for four-year terms expiring September 1, 2030. Chair Smith supported the reappointments based on the members' mining experience. Commissioner Martin raised potential conflict-of-interest concerns and requested review by Legal Counsel before the Board acted. The matter was tabled to the next County Administration Workshop pending that review.

b. Agricultural Education Grants - 4-H Extension Service District

Commissioner Richardson introduced discussion of approximately \$30,000 in Agricultural Education Grant funding associated with the 4-H Extension Service District and the need to establish a consistent application and selection process. The Board discussed whether a separate advisory committee was necessary, potential conflicts of interest, a once-a-year application period, eligibility criteria, and possible applicants such as FFA or 4-H clubs. The Board directed Commissioner Richardson to develop a proposed process and timeline and return with additional information regarding the funding source, frequency, eligibility criteria, and application requirements.

c. DEQ - Outstanding Resource Water Designation; Illinois River and Rough & Ready Creek

Commissioner Richardson discussed the Oregon Department of Environmental Quality's rulemaking concerning a proposed Outstanding Resource Water designation for portions of the Illinois River and Rough & Ready Creek. He expressed concern that the designation could affect groundwater-connected activities, future municipal wastewater permitting, industrial lands in the Illinois Valley, and potential biomass or wildfire-reduction economic-development projects. Richardson presented a draft County comment letter requesting that Josephine County have representation during the rulemaking process and indicated his willingness to serve as the County representative. The Board supported the letter and County participation without objection.

4. OTHER

Commissioner Martin presented a request from the Applegate Daughters of the American Revolution to host the American Battlefield Trust traveling exhibit in the Anne G. Basker Auditorium from December 8 through December 18, 2026. The exhibit would require approximately 500 square feet, would be staffed while open, and is intended to be promoted to local schools and the public. The Board supported the concept and directed staff to verify Auditorium availability, including any Circuit Court conflicts, and confirm that the sponsoring organization meets the County's requirements for fee-free use before proceeding.

5. ADDITIONAL SUBJECT MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS/ANNOUNCEMENTS:

The Board announced that the Whitehorse Park ribbon-cutting scheduled for September 2 had been canceled because of rain and would be rescheduled. Commissioners welcomed the rainfall while noting that fire-season conditions could continue depending on weather. Commissioner Richardson also reported that County benefit enrollment had improved substantially, with approximately 20 employees remaining incomplete at the close of the enrollment campaign, and thanked departments and employees for their participation.

The meeting adjourned at 2:32 p.m.